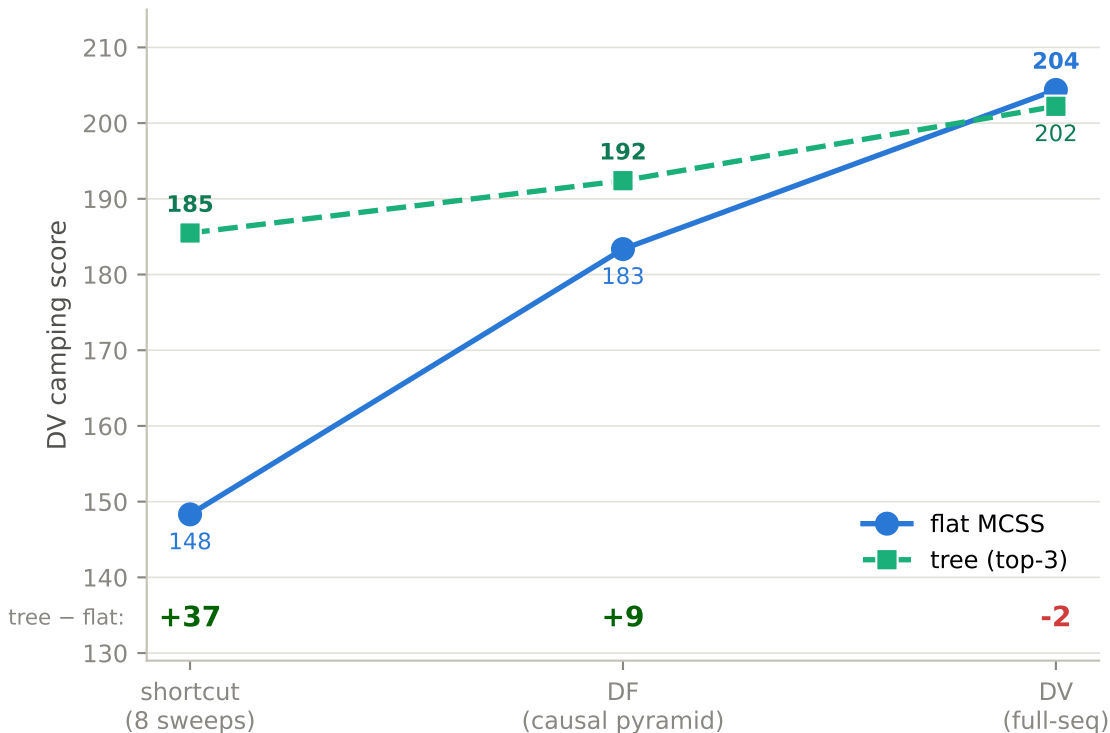


Search is an equalizer: gain grows as the flat baseline weakens



maze2d-large, 5-seed pooled (DF, shortcut); DV start-matched vs compute-matched k256. Gap = the headroom.